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Introduction

11.0 Introduction

Weights of different periods and also measures of volume have been uncovered in various archaeological sites. The weights generally are made of stone, sometimes of metal. They are spherical in shape, and are identified by having their names engraved on them. The measures of volume are usually containers, stone or clay jars, with the name of the measure inscribed on them. Because of their rustic manufacture, they are not "accurate" or "just" in a precise modern sense. However, they served as normative standards in a given period and region, although they differed according to time and place. For this reason the equivalences in terms of modern weights and measures are only approximate.

Translators who make use of tables of equivalents from more than one reference book may be confused when they notice that different books sometimes give different values for the same biblical units. However, this only shows that there is some uncertainty about some of the units. In the case of these particular units, each translator will have to decide which value he will base his translation on. Here it is probably best to stick to what is recommended by one reliable reference book for the whole range of biblical weights and measures. (In most instances the variation between the values given in different books is not significant as far as the main meaning of the text is concerned.)

If a translation retains the original terms, then it should supply footnotes and/or tables so the reader can understand them. In common-language translations, where the terms are converted in the text into modern equivalents it may not be necessary to include a table of coins or weights and measures. This is true even of study editions based on a common-language translation. You will notice in the lists which follow that most weights, measures, and monetary units appear relatively few times in the Bible. Of the approximately forty-five items that are listed below, only five appear in more than ten places and only eight in more than five places. This means that most items can be annotated every time they appear, while those few items that occur more often can be discussed in a glossary.

Rounding off

11.0.1 Rounding off

Many biblical weights and measures are given in round figures or whole numbers. When they are converted to modern equivalents, the resulting figures will often have one or two decimal places. This can give the modern reader the impression of a measurement that is more precise than was actually the case. To avoid this, it is recommended that numbers be rounded off as much as possible to the same number of significant figures as was the case in the original text. The "significant" figures are the digits other than the place holding zeros in a given measurement; for example, if the original measurement is 40, it has one significant figure, that is, one digit followed by a zero in a two-digit number. If the conversion of this measurement results in a modern equivalent of 189, rounding off to one significant figure would yield 200, that is, one digit followed by zeros in a three-digit number. We may take an example from LUK 24:13, where the distance is given as 60 stadia in the Greek text. The number 60 has one significant figure. One stadion equals 607 feet, so 60 stadia are 6.9 miles. Rounding off 6.9 miles to one significant figure would mean a translation of "7 miles" (so RSVGNT).

Symbolic numbers

11.0.2 Symbolic numbers

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In several places in the book of Revelation, and perhaps elsewhere, measurements are given which probably have symbolic meaning. Since the numbers themselves are part of the message (and perhaps a more important part than the actual measurements), these numbers should not be obscured by converting them to modern equivalents. The following passages fall into this category and are discussed below: REV 14:20; REV 16:21; REV 21:16; REV 21:17.

The treatment that follows does not pretend to be comprehensive nor even to take into consideration variations in values from one time period to another and from one location to another. The values suggested, however, should be sufficient to aid a translator to produce renderings that will give the readers a reasonable idea of size and volume.

In the discussions that follow, weights and measures are generally given in ascending order, from small to large. These discussions should be used together with the tables that appear below.